of massive castles, wielding some of the deadliest weapons known to man, including the musket.

When the cinders from the last battle cooled in 1600, the Tokugawa family emerged supreme. Yet far from attempting to destroy all opposition, it instead instituted a quasi-centralized feudal regime, allowing 250 other semiautonomous domains to carve up the country. Then, roughly forty years after taking power, they promulgated a series of edicts designed to tightly control foreign relations, making supervision of overseas contacts a prerogative of the *shogunate*, the Tokugawa military bureaucracy, which served as a de facto government of the nation. These maritime exclusion edicts, restricting trade with Chinese and Dutch merchants primarily to the city of Nagasaki on the far southwestern home island of Kyushu, later gave rise to the legend of the era of isolation, the so-called *sakoku* or "closed country." Only when Commodore Matthew Perry arrived with his "Black Ships" in 1853 was Japan forced to "open" itself to the world, at least in the popular Western imagination.

Nearly four hundred years after the exclusion edicts were enacted, Japan retains the mystique of being a land apart, a country of the world but perhaps not fully in it. Some of this impression is sheer exoticization, a form of the "Orientalism" made famous (and abused) by the late Edward Said. Some of it has been used skillfully by the Japanese themselves, to deflect foreign pressure or criticism. And some of it is real, the fruit of a historical experience unique in its own ways. One of Japan's first recorded poems, in the imperial anthology *Kojiki*, from the early eighth century, celebrated an "eightfold fence" separating Japan from other lands and peoples, a realm where the gods dwelled.

Japan, of course, has never been isolated from the world around it. The emergence of Japan's first proto-state, in roughly the fourth century, was marked by the importation of metal goods from the continent, while Buddhism was introduced in 550, according to records. When Nara's Great Buddha statue was consecrated in 754, monks from as far away as India came to the ceremony, and glass from seventh-century Persia can be found today in Nara's Imperial Treasury. Most